

Evaluating Cryptographic API Misuse Detectors for Go

Vivi Andersson, Martin Monperrus

KTH Royal Institute of Technology, Stockholm, Sweden

April 18, 2026
Rio de Janeiro, Brazil
SVM 2026

A Cryptographic API Misuse

Traefik, CVE-2025-66491. ingress-nginx provider:

```
InsecureSkipVerify: strings.ToLower(  
    ptr.Deref(cfg.ProxySSLVerify, "off")) ==  
    "on",
```

- The user sets proxy-ssl-verify: "on", expecting TLS verification to be **enabled**.
- Expression evaluates to true, InsecureSkipVerify becomes true, inverting security assumptions.
- TLS encryption remains, but backend authentication is disabled: Traefik may trust a spoofed backend.

Why Go

- **Go runs critical infrastructure:** Kubernetes, Terraform, Traefik, Let's Encrypt's Boulder.
- Cryptographic misuses reach production, for example CVE-2025-66491 in Traefik and CVE-2024-45337 in [golang.org/x/ssh](https://go.dev/issue/60000).
- Four Go detectors exist (GOPHER, CODEQL, GOSEC, SNYK CODE), but none have been systematically evaluated.

Contribution

The first comparative study of cryptographic API misuse detectors for Go.

Research Questions

- **RQ1.** What is the design space of state-of-the-art tools for detecting cryptographic API misuses in Go?
 - ▶ We survey the tools and consolidate a taxonomy of 14 Go crypto misuse classes.
- **RQ2.** To what extent are crypto misuse detection tools for Go consistent with each other?
 - ▶ We run all four tools on 328 security-relevant Go projects and compare their findings.

Sourced Tools

CodeQL

GitHub • Open source



Datalog queries over a fact database, with data-flow reasoning.

Gosec

Community • Open source



SSA for some rules, AST pattern matching for others.

Gopher

Academic • Binary-only



SSA-based taint tracking, with dynamically updatable rules.

Snyk Code

Commercial • Proprietary



Static analysis product; implementation details undisclosed.

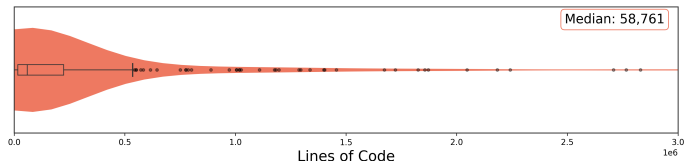
RQ1: Taxonomy and Tool Coverage

Category	#	Rule	CodeQL	Gopher	Gosec	Snyk
Primitives	01	Insecure algorithms		✓	✓	✓
	02	Insecure PRNG	✓	✓	✓	✓
	03	Deprecated Go function		✓		
Key mgmt	04	Constant/predictable key		✓		
	05	Short key length	✓	✓	✓	✓
	06	Static/predictable IV		✓	✓	
PBKDF	07	Short salt length		✓		
	08	Predictable salt		✓		
	09	Low hash iterations		✓		
Transport	10	HTTP protocol		✓		
	11	TLS/SSL issues	✓	✓	✓	✓
SSH	12	Insecure SSH suite		✓		
	13	No host key validation	✓	✓	✓	
Token	14	No JWT verification	✓			

- **Coverage:** Gopher (13) > Gosec (6) > CodeQL (5) > Snyk Code (4)
- **All tools:** 3 of 14 rules (#02, #05, #11) are covered by all

RQ2: Dataset

- **328 open-source Go repositories**, filtered from a curated set of 920 popular projects.
- Kept only actively maintained projects (commit within the past year, stable release) where cryptography is core.
- Size is right-skewed: median 58,761 LOC.



RQ2: Tool Execution and Coverage

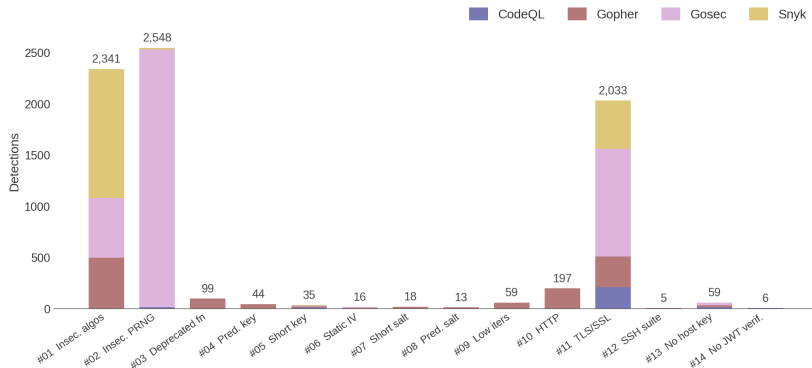
	CodeQL	Gopher	Gosec	Snyk
Projects analyzed (%)	91.8	77.1	100	100
With findings (% of analyzed)	30.9	64.8	84.5	92.7
With findings (% of dataset)	28.4	50.0	84.5	92.7

Coverage

SNYK CODE and GOSSEC analyze all 328 projects, while GOPHER fails on 75 (runtime errors) and CODEQL on 27 (database build errors).

RQ2: Raw Findings by Tool

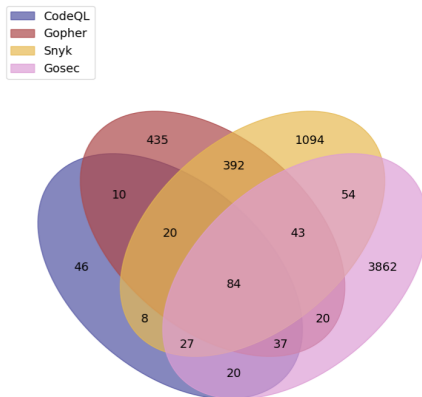
- 7,473 findings across 328 projects



- GOPHER uniquely detects issues in #04 Predictable Key
- Excessive detections indicate insensitive detection (e.g., #01, #02, #11)

RQ2: Line Level Agreement

- 6,152 unique flagged lines across the dataset.
- Only **1.3%** are flagged by **all four** tools. **11.6%** are flagged by at least **two**.



RQ2: Per-Rule Agreement

Category	#	Rule	CodeQL	Gopher	Gosec	Snyk
Primitives	01	Insecure algorithms		✓	✓	✓
	02	Insecure PRNG	✓	✓	✓	✓
	03	Deprecated Go function		✓		
Key mgmt	04	Constant/predictable key		✓		
	05	Short key length	✓	✓	✓	✓
	06	Static/predictable IV		✓	✓	
PBKDF	07	Short salt length		✓		
	08	Predictable salt		✓		
	09	Low hash iterations		✓		
Transport	10	HTTP protocol		✓		
	11	TLS/SSL issues	✓	✓	✓	✓
SSH	12	Insecure SSH suite		✓		
	13	No host key validation	✓	✓	✓	
Token	14	No JWT verification	✓			

- Per-rule agreement matches on (project, file, line, rule)

RQ2: Agreement on Rule #05

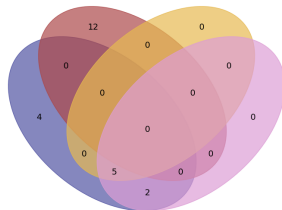
WIP

Concrete misuse: short RSA key

```
priv, err := rsa.GenerateKey(  
    rand.Reader, 1024)
```

- 1024-bit RSA is below current recommendations.
- Weak keys make long-term impersonation or decryption more realistic.

Overlap. All four tools support Rule #05, but agreement is still low: they differ on whether mock/example code and broader patterns should count.



RQ2: Agreement on Rule #11

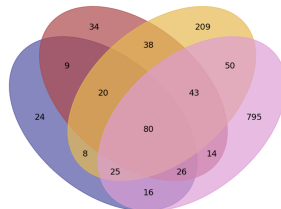
WIP

Concrete misuse: TLS certificate checks disabled

```
tls.Config{  
    InsecureSkipVerify: true,  
}
```

- TLS stays encrypted, but peer authentication is gone.
- A machine-in-the-middle can present its own certificate and be trusted.

Overlap. This is the largest class. All tools find true positives here, but Gosec and SNYK CODE contribute many tool-unique alerts, with different precision levels.



RQ2: Agreement on Rule #13

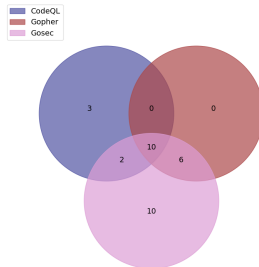
WIP

Concrete misuse: SSH host key verification disabled in keadm batch

```
HostKeyCallback: func(...) error
{
    return nil
},
```

- The SSH client accepts any server host key, so the remote node identity is never authenticated.
- If an attacker redirects the connection, keadm batch may connect to the wrong host; with password authentication, SSH credentials may be exposed.

Overlap. GOSEC primarily matches InsecureIgnoreHostKey. CODEQL also detects equivalent custom callbacks, so the low overlap reflects deeper semantic coverage.



Issues in Practice

WIP, maybe covered in the examples.?

1. Context-dependent usage

Rule #05, flagged by GOPHER

```
h := blake2b.New512(nil)    // bug if used as a MAC
                             // fine for content hashing
```

Static analysis cannot distinguish security-critical vs. benign usage.

2. Pattern match misses the equivalent

Rule #13, only CODEQL

```
cfg.HostKeyCallback = func(...) error { return nil }
```

CODEQL detects this pattern; the other tools do not report it in our study.

3. Field name flagged, value ignored

Rule #11, GOSec false positive

```
tlsConfig := &tls.Config{Certificates: []tls.Certificate{cert}, RootCAs: roots}
setTLSDefaults(tlsConfig) // MinVersion 1.2 = OK
```

GOSec lacks data flow capabilities and flags false positives.

WIP, add takeaway or something.

- **For practitioners:** no single detector is enough. The tools miss different things, so relying on one leaves systematic blind spots.
- **For evaluators:** raw counts mislead. On insecure PRNG detection, GOSec reports 2,517 findings where GOPHER reports 0, on the same code and for the same rule.
- **For tool builders:** the gap is qualitative, not only quantitative. The tools differ in rule coverage and in how much program context they model.

- **API-level security invariants.** The paper points to formalization and enforcement of API-level security invariants as a research need.
- **More precise static reasoning.** Several disagreements come from limited context sensitivity around how values are configured and used.

Thank you

Questions and discussion